CSIS | KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Friday, November 13, 2026 No. 233 14 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. FM Cho Hyun met Wang Yi in Beijing to prepare Lee-Xi APEC summit in Shenzhen next week.
2. North Korea changed its national flag aspect ratio from 1:2 to 1:1.65, the first change since 1948.
3. DOJ obtained court authorization to seize over $1.2 billion stolen from Binance by DPRK-linked hackers.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,290.53	1,336.17	$95.95	41%	Today	3.00%
−1.0%	−0.0%	+0.1%	+2 pts Nov 3-5	public appearance	Oct 2026

01 | TOP STORIES

Hankyoreh, China-Korea

FM Cho, Wang Yi meet in Beijing ahead of Lee-Xi APEC summit

Cho Hyun met **Wang Yi** at Beijing's Diaoyutai State Guesthouse on November 13, with Cho calling the Korean Peninsula issue 'South Korea's vital interest' and Wang assessing that the bilateral relationship has 'returned to the normal track of improvement and development.' Both sides cited a projected *1,000-fold increase in people-to-people exchanges* and more than 40% trade growth in 2026.

NK News / Bloomberg, DPRK

DOJ obtains court authorization to seize $1.2B in DPRK-linked Binance funds

The US Department of Justice announced coordinated actions to disrupt North Korea's cryptocurrency theft operations, obtaining court authorization to seize *over $1.2 billion* stolen from Binance.

The actions target two operations attributed to DPRK state-sponsored actors: a social engineering campaign dubbed 'FaceStealer' and a separate exchange hack. Bloomberg separately reported the broader context of a *$2.7 billion* freeze linked to the same DPRK Binance hacking operation.

NK News / Yonhap, DPRK

North Korea changes flag aspect ratio for first time since 1948

North Korea's official website Naenara began displaying its national flag with a new aspect ratio of *1:1.65*, replacing the 1:2 ratio that had been in place since the country's establishment in 1948. The two thin white stripes also appear thicker than before.

The change, embedded in the revised constitution, is the latest in a series of moves by **Kim Jong Un** to build a distinct national identity separate from the founding era of Kim Il Sung.

Reuters / Korea Times, Technology

South Korea confirms Nvidia will keep GPU supply pledges after Jensen Huang's resignation

South Korea's science ministry confirmed that Nvidia has reaffirmed its commitment to supply *260,000 graphics processing units (GPUs)* to South Korea for AI factory buildouts despite the resignation of CEO **Jensen Huang** following affair allegations.

The ministry held a meeting with Nvidia on pending issues and confirmed cooperation plans with Samsung Electronics, SK Group, Hyundai Motor Group, and Naver Cloud remain on track. The science minister posted separately on Facebook noting GPU supply and Korean partnership programs would proceed as company-level commitments.

02 | OVERNIGHT

NK News, DPRK

FM Cho: chance of Kim Jong Un appearing at APEC in Shenzhen 'not very high'

Cho made the remark to reporters at Gimpo Airport before departing for Beijing.

Reuters, DPRK

FBI: North Korean hackers stole more than $400 million using video-image social engineering

FBI attributed thefts to DPRK state-sponsored actors over the past 18 months.

Korea.net, US-Korea

President Lee to attend ASEAN summit in Philippines and APEC in Shenzhen Nov 16-19

National Security Adviser Wi Sung-lac announced the schedule; Lee will hold bilateral sessions and present AI and supply-chain cooperation agenda.

Dong-A Ilbo, ROK Economy

Lee Jae-myung and Samsung chairman Lee Jae-yong exchange praise at Chungcheong mega-project groundbreaking

First meeting between the two leaders in about three months; Samsung chair called the projects 'a historic challenge to reshape the future of South Korea.'

Korea Times, Energy

Seoul freezes fuel price caps for fifth consecutive period as Brent nears $96

Gasoline cap stays at 1,784 won per liter for four weeks from Saturday; government has held caps unchanged for 20 weeks since June 27.

NK News, DPRK

North Korea's top diplomat calls G7 denuclearization demand 'vicious criticism' of DPRK rights

FM Choe accused the US and UK of posing a 'greater nuclear threat' and said North Korea's determination 'would not be shaken by external pressure.'

03 | STAT OF THE DAY

$1.2B

DPRK crypto funds subject to US seizure order from Binance

The DOJ announced coordinated actions to disrupt North Korea's virtual currency theft, targeting a social engineering campaign dubbed FaceStealer and the Binance hack.

NK News, Nov 13 2026

04 | PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

Public appearance: Kim Jong Un inspected a second major east-coast naval base under construction on November 12, ordering that it be completed on the schedule and to the quality standard set by the party central.

No KCNA watch flag. 5 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

> *"Modern naval base construction is a major core project directly linked to our state's safety and defense of maritime sovereignty, and must unconditionally be completed within the period decided by the party central and at the quality level demanded by the party central."*
>
> **Kim Jong Un**, (LEAD) N. Korea's Kim inspects east coast naval base under construction, urges timely completion

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

Yonhap News Agency, Kim Jong Un

Kim Jong Un inspects east-coast naval base, orders timely completion

KCNA confirmed Kim inspected a major naval base construction site on the east coast on November 12 and issued an order for timely completion at the quality standard set by the party central.

NK News

North Korea faked November 4 cluster warhead test, used doctored photos from 2022

NK News reports that North Korea's November 4 cluster warhead test was faked, with KCNA releasing doctored photographs from 2022 rather than images of a live test.

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Choe Son Hui, Foreign Minister, DPRK

Choe Son Hui issued a statement via KCNA calling the G7's demand for denuclearization 'vicious criticism against Pyongyang's constitutional rights' and declaring that North Korea's nuclear status 'can never be a subject of Western countries' debate.'

> **Bottom line:** State media led with Kim's east-coast naval base inspection and the DPRK flag redesign embedded in the revised constitution; NK News separately reported that North Korea faked its November 4 cluster warhead test using 2022 imagery.

05 | ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Friday, November 13, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Vice FM Kim Jin-a

Vice FM meets UN DPPA Under-Secretary-General DiCarlo on Korean Peninsula and global peace

Kim Jin-a met Rosemary DiCarlo at the MOFA building on November 13 to exchange views on Korea-UN peace and security cooperation, North Korea issues, and financial contributions to the UN's Multi-Year Appeal conflict-prevention fund.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Strategic Intelligence Director Jeong Yeon-doo

Korea co-hosts 25th Korea-UN Disarmament and Nonproliferation Conference in Seoul

Jeong Yeon-doo opened the two-day conference and separately met UN High Representative for Disarmament Affairs Izumi Nakamitsu; the session focused on responsible military AI use. Nakamitsu warned rapid AI advances heighten miscalculation risks.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**
Reported **UPI**

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

MOFA

MOFA hosts 10th Economic Security Diplomacy Forum with US, European, Japanese experts

The forum held November 13 at Four Seasons Hotel Seoul under the theme 'Beyond Crisis to the Future' included Philip Luck of CSIS Economics Program, Tobias Gehrke of the European Council on Foreign Relations, and Todo Yasuyuki of Waseda University/RIETI.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Special Envoy Kang Geum-sil

Korea's presidential COP31 envoy calls for bold climate action at Antalya Leaders Summit

Special Envoy Kang Geum-sil delivered a speech at the COP31 Antalya Leaders Summit on November 12 announcing Korea's 2035 Nationally Determined Contribution and K-Green Transformation strategy, and expressed support for the Turkish presidency's '35 by 35 global electrification pledge.'

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

PRESIDENTIAL OFFICE

President Lee Jae-myung

President Lee holds capital markets policy roundtable at Korea Exchange, pledges governance reform

President Lee Jae-myung met capital markets experts at the Korea Exchange and stated the core of capital market reform is 'restoring trust through fair and transparent rules applied without exception.' He called for strengthening minority shareholder protections and activating mergers and acquisitions to close Korea's valuation discount.

Primary **Korea.kr**

MINISTRY OF TRADE, INDUSTRY AND RESOURCES

MOTIR Minister

MOTIR activates emergency management for Czech nuclear project after contractor breakdown

The minister chaired a meeting with public enterprise heads to review milestone achievement, new contractor selection, and business continuity following the collapse of negotiations between Korea Hydro and Nuclear Power and domestic construction firms over the Czech nuclear project. The minister pledged fair and transparent contractor selection and stated government will directly engage with Czech counterparts on pending issues.

Minister, Trade/Industry (MOTIR) on X

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Oh Hyun-ju NOMINATED

KOICA (Korea International Cooperation Agency) President, 15th

The government announced Oh Hyun-ju, former third deputy chief of the National Security Office, will be appointed KOICA president on November 16. Oh has over 30 years of diplomatic experience including as ambassador to the Holy See, deputy chief of mission to the UN, and director of the development cooperation bureau.

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Assembly member exchanges with Unification Minister Chung Dong-young on terminology for North Korean defectors

Unification Committee (National Assembly)

PPP lawmaker Ju Ho-young challenged Unification Minister Chung Dong-young over his use of the term 'northward-facing people' for North Korean defectors, asking if southward-facing people could similarly be called 'southward-facing people,' reflecting ongoing contestation over North Korea policy framing.

06 US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff currently in force. The Section 301 investigation launched March 11 against South Korea and 15 other trading partners is now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding (MASGA), $200B strategic sectors, $100B US energy purchases; no official drawdown figure reported to date.

07 CAPITOL HILL

Korea JoongAng Daily, House, Legislation

US House passes bill shielding small businesses from North Korea cyber threats

The House passed legislation requiring small businesses to adopt mandatory cyber defense guidelines to counter threats from North Korea and other hostile state actors including through illicit IT worker infiltration; the bill moves to the Senate.

08 NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

Korea Times, Japan-Korea

Seoul holds third straight separate Sado mine memorial, presses Japan on forced labor history

Ambassador Lee Hyuk called the Sado mine a site of government-arranged forced labor under Japanese colonial rule; Tokyo held a separate parallel event, maintaining its own framing of the site's history.

09 KOREA AND THE WORLD

Kyiv Post, Ukraine, Aid

Seoul keeps Ukraine aid flowing despite diplomatic row over North Korean POWs

South Korea's presidential office said it expects 'progress on issues with Ukraine after useful talks in Paris,' with Seoul maintaining its $100 million aid commitment despite an unresolved diplomatic dispute over North Korean prisoners of war captured on the Ukrainian front.

10 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

newneek.co

KOSPI fell 23% in one month, largest drop among major global markets; foreign capital exits for ninth consecutive month

The KOSPI has shed *23%* in the past month to rank as the worst-performing major market globally, with foreign investors withdrawing funds for nine consecutive months. The FSC chairman said the market stabilization fund should be deployed only in 'extremely urgent and exceptional circumstances.'

businesspost.co.kr

October export price index rose 0.7% on semiconductor price gains; import prices fell 1.8%

Rising semiconductor export prices drove a *0.7%* monthly gain in South Korea's export price index in October, while import prices fell 1.8%. The divergence reflects continued demand for advanced chips even as broader market sentiment weakens.

Dong-A Ilbo

Seoul and ruling party unveil financial holding company governance reforms

The government and Democratic Party proposed requiring CEO appointments at bank holding companies to go through shareholder general meetings rather than boards, and raising approval thresholds for nominations to two-thirds for initial appointments and three-quarters for reappointments. The measures are framed as a response to President Lee Jae-myung's December 2025 remarks about a 'corrupt inner circle' in finance.

11 UPCOMING

NOV 16

President Lee departs for ASEAN Summit in Manila

Lee Jae-myung will attend a bilateral summit with ASEAN in Manila and the ASEAN-Mekong, ASEAN Plus Three, and East Asia Summits on November 16-17 before flying to Shenzhen for APEC.

NOV 18

Lee Jae-myung attends APEC CEO Summit in Shenzhen

President Lee flies to Shenzhen on November 18 for APEC, beginning with the CEO Summit; a bilateral with Xi Jinping is expected on the margins, their first meeting in ten months.

NOV 20

Former PM Han Deok-su detention warrant expires

South Korean media report the special prosecutor has flagged that former Prime Minister Han Deok-su's detention warrant expires around November 20; the Supreme Court's pending ruling on the case is drawing attention.

12 | ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

MSIT Minister (@msitminister), November 13

"Following news of Jensen Huang's resignation, we held a meeting with Nvidia this morning chaired by the second vice minister. Nvidia reconfirmed at the company level that the planned supply of 260,000 advanced GPUs and cooperation with Korean companies will proceed as announced. Plans for NVLink integration with domestic AI chips, AI computing infrastructure, physical AI joint research, talent development, and holding GTC in Korea will also continue."

The science ministry's morning-of confirmation meeting with Nvidia followed Jensen Huang's resignation; the government's own plan to procure 50,000 GPUs is also said to be on track. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

STATEMENTS

Lee Jae-myung

"The most important thing is restoring market trust. When the capital market is trusted, our companies get properly valued and citizens and investors can invest with confidence."

Lee's remarks came alongside proposals by the government and ruling Democratic Party to reform CEO succession rules at financial holding companies, the same day he met Samsung chairman Lee Jae-yong at the Chungcheong project groundbreaking. **Source**

Cho Hyun

"The Korean Peninsula issue is the vital interest of the Republic of Korea, and the peace and stability of the Korean Peninsula is the common interest of both countries."

Source

COMMENTARY

The 2026 U.S. Midterm Elections: Implications for OPCON Transition and Seoul's Nuclear Pursuits. The Asan Institute analyzes how the 2026 US midterm results affect two of Seoul's key security priorities: wartime operational control transition from the United States and South Korea's nuclear submarine ambitions. Congressional dynamics, specifically Democratic skepticism toward Korean nuclear-powered vessel technology transfer, now constrain the ROK's strategic options. The piece situates these debates within the broader context of alliance management under the second Trump administration. (asaninst.org)

Mind the Gap: Keeping Export Compliance Within Reach as BIS Focuses on Enforcement. Drawing on a September 30 CSIS-University of Georgia technology export controls conference, the piece documents how BIS is now focused on enforcement rather than outreach, transferring compliance burdens to industry. Small and medium-sized companies lack the dedicated compliance staff to absorb this shift, risking uneven access to policymakers. The authors call for collaborative approaches to prevent enforcement from undermining US technology leadership, directly relevant to Samsung and SK Hynix navigating annual BIS export licenses for their China operations. (Kate Koren, Kevin Kurland, Joshua Massey, Ryan Powers, CSIS)

RESEARCH

The U.S.-ROK Joint Fact Sheet: Implementation One Year On. The NBR piece assesses one year of implementation of the US-ROK joint fact sheet, examining how commitments on extended deterrence, wartime operational control, and alliance coordination have been carried out in practice. The analysis connects the fact sheet's provisions to the alliance's current posture under the second Trump administration. It provides a baseline against which ongoing alliance management debates, including OPCON transfer and nuclear consultative mechanisms, can be measured. (National Bureau of Asian Research (NBR), A)

Implication: Tracking implementation gaps one year on is directly actionable for NSC and State Department Korea desk officers preparing for the Lee-Trump meeting at APEC and assessing the alliance's condition.

13 | PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

41%

+2 pts vs Oct 27-29
Gallup Korea
November 3-5, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 8 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
36%	28%	28%

Gallup Korea publishes weekly; this reading is 1 week old (November 3-5, 2026).

14 | THE WIRE

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

NK News

Russia and North Korea plan 14-daily-round-trip Vladivostok-Rason bus service over new bridge

Applications filed with Russia's Transport Ministry envision a 203.3-mile (327.2 km) route; experts note the buses will likely transport DPRK workers more than Russian tourists.

NK News

Dandong bus factory runs at full capacity after Kim Jong Un's October visit

Huanghai Automobile's Dandong plant announced it is operating at full capacity with automated welding and painting lines running at high speed, raising questions about planned vehicle exports to the DPRK.

DPRK

NK News

Seoul court sentences three to prison for helping DPRK cyber actors create gambling websites

The Seoul Central District Court sentenced one defendant to four years and two others to three years each for violating the National Security Act and establishing illegal gambling operations in support of North Korean cyber actors.

15 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

New imagery reports, Nov 11-12

38 North publishes strategic assessment of North Korea's Choe Hyon surface warship and its implications for the West Sea Fleet

38 North's analysis of the Choe Hyon destroyer examines its capabilities and strategic implications for North Korea's naval modernization posture. The report is paired with KCNA-confirmed reporting that Kim Jong Un inspected a second east-coast

naval base project on November 12 and ordered timely completion. NK News separately identified a second major naval base project on the east coast, beyond the Munchon-area site Kim inspected.

Sinpo South Shipyard (Activity/Up)

38 North: The Choe Hyon, North Korean Navy Surface Ship, and Its Strategic Implications NK News: Second major North Korean naval base project identified on east coast

ACTIVITY, RISING

Sinpo South Shipyard

As of May 2025: Hero Kim Kun Ok SLBM submarine exited drydock after 2+ years of fitting-out but was still not operational. New submarine construction begun in separate bay. NK Pro satellite analysis (Oct 20 2026) separately reports North Korea's Nampho Shipyard missed a deadline earlier in Oct 2026 to launch a 5,000-ton naval destroyer, with hull sections visible at two potential outdoor assembly areas. 38 North analysis published Oct 30 documents public display of a vessel described as a 'Tactical Nuclear Attack' submarine. Kim Jong Un inspected Nampho Shipyard on Nov 7 (reported Nov 8 by KCNA), announcing a new warship under construction larger than the destroyer built last year. NK News reported on Nov 6 that North Korea has expanded warship construction to a third shipyard. 38 North published analysis on Nov 11 of the Choe Hyon destroyer and its strategic implications for the West Sea Fleet. NK News identified a second major east-coast naval base project on Nov 13, beyond the Munchon-area site Kim inspected on Nov 12.

imagery as of 2026-11-13

ACTIVITY, RISING

Tumangang-Khasan (NK-Russia border)

As of March 2026: Road bridge construction accelerated, completion target moved to Summer 2026. Passenger rail service resumed mid-2025. Ore and tank car traffic at highest levels since project began. This report is over six months old and may not reflect the current state. Russian Transport Ministry applications filed Nov 13 for a 14-daily-round-trip Vladivostok-Rason bus route over the new vehicle bridge, with experts noting the service will likely transport DPRK workers more than Russian tourists.

imagery as of 2026-11-13

ACTIVITY, RISING

Sinuiju-Dandong (NK-China border)

38 North satellite imagery from October 16 confirms trucks traversing the New Yalu River (DPRK-Friendship) Bridge one day after the October 15 official opening, marking the start of commercial vehicle traffic. Daily NK reports (Oct 31) that North Korean trucks have still not joined Chinese cargo trucks on the bridge two weeks after the Oct 15 opening; North Korean transport officials are still preparing vehicles. North Korea-China trade reached $299M in September 2026, the second-highest monthly total in 2026. Kim Jong Un crossed the New Yalu River Bridge on October 24 during his unannounced visit to Dandong. Daily NK reports on Nov 3, 2026 that North Korea is courting Chinese investors to build hotels and shopping complexes in Sinuiju. NK News reports a surge in North Korean delegations visiting China, putting commercial ties in focus. Daily NK reports Nov 12 that Chinese truck drivers who relied on side income ferrying parcels across the new bridge are souring on operations due to tighter customs checks and movement controls since the October opening. Huanghai Automobile's Dandong bus factory announced it is operating at full capacity on Nov 13 following Kim Jong Un's October visit, raising questions about potential vehicle exports to the DPRK.

imagery as of 2026-11-13

8 other monitored sites: no new reporting since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 233

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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